

Cloudinary Free Plan Analysis: Otulia

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Project: Otulia (Luxury Marketplace MERN Stack)

Plan: Cloudinary Free Tier (25 Credits/Month)

1. Executive Summary

The Cloudinary Free Plan is **sufficient** for the launch and early growth phase of Otulia. It can support approximately **1,000+ active luxury listings** if optimized correctly. However, strict adherence to optimization best practices is required to avoid hitting bandwidth limits.

The Verdict: You can operate for 6-12 months on the free tier before needing to upgrade (\$89/mo), assuming standard marketplace growth.

2. Capacity Analysis (The Math)

Cloudinary uses a "Credit" system. You get **25 Credits per month**.

- 1 Credit = 1 GB Managed Storage
- 1 Credit = 1 GB Bandwidth (Viewing images)
- 1 Credit = 1,000 Transformations (Resizing/Cropping)

Otulia's Estimated Capacity

- **Average Listing:** 10 High-Quality Images
- **Optimization:** 5MB original upload → reduced to ~200KB via `f_auto,q_auto`.
- **Storage Cost:** ~5MB per listing (Originals + Optimized versions).
- **Max Listings (Pure Storage):** ~5,000 Listings.
- **Real World Limit:** ~1,000 Listings (Leaving 75% of credits for Bandwidth/Views).

3. The "Danger Zones" (Risks)

Risk 1: Bandwidth is the Killer

Storage is cheap; viewing is expensive. If you place a **2MB un-optimized banner** on your homepage and get 10,000 visitors, that consumes **20 GB (20 Credits)** in a single day. You will hit your monthly limit immediately.

Risk 2: Heavy Video

A single 50MB yacht tour video viewed 500 times = 25GB. Do **not** host long videos on the free tier.

4. Strategic Recommendations (Implementation Guide)

To safely stay on the free plan, implement these rules in your MERN stack immediately:

- **Code Rule #1 (Crucial):** Always append `f_auto,q_auto` to every image URL you display in your React frontend.
Example: `cloudinary.com/.../upload/f_auto,q_auto/yacht.jpg`
- **Upload Limit:** Restrict users to a maximum of **10 images** per listing.
- **File Size Limit:** Reject uploads larger than **5 MB** in your React Dropzone component.
- **Video Policy:** Use YouTube or Vimeo for property tours. Store the embed URL in MongoDB. Only use Cloudinary for short (5-second) silent loops if necessary.

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